In his Ibadat Khana, Akbar may have encouraged every kind of opinion, but when faced with an enemy, he was still the same man who had raced after Mirza Ibrahim in Sarnal and made latecomers beg to join the cactus-ridden battle. Akbar was furious at his peacenik amirs, and quite inclined to gallop away as he had done then. '[T]he officers are afraid of the cold,' he declared, quite correctly – many of them were Hindustani, they had never known a winter – 'I'll leave them all behind'.

Abul Fazl reappeared in court the next day, and wondered why the atmosphere was so tense. 'Traces of anger [still] shone from the emperor's brow,' he writes.[32] When Akbar summoned him and began an interrogation, the wretched man – he had only been a mansabdar for about five years – 'fell into despondency, and came into a condition which may no evil-doer fall into'.[33] Abul Fazl was in a terrible state, but no matter how he protested his innocence, Akbar was unrelenting. It wasn't six months since he had lost trust in another of his chosen men (Shah Mansur, as Abul Fazl writes, became vizier without the recommendation of courtiers, and without experience). Would the emperor now re-examine his trust in another of his hand-picked talents?

One by one, Akbar summoned the amirs to confirm what Abul Fazl had said at the meeting, and one by one they 'took the same road of impudent assertion'.

'I almost lost my mind,'[34] Abul Fazl remembers. He, too, may have recalled Shah Mansur's body hanging from a tree. Finally – thankfully! – one of the amirs, unnamed but memorably described as a man with nothing to fear, having 'too many enemies to ever rise to any prominence',[35] came to the scribe's defence. Akbar, already moved to sympathy by Abul Fazl's distracted state, closed the investigation and marched on.

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It was exactly this kind of dissension and backbiting amongst Akbar's men that Mirza Hakim and his advisers were relying upon. 'The Turanis and Persians who are in the imperial army will join us without fighting,' was their calculation, according to Abul Fazl, 'and the brave Rajputs and gallant Afghans will end their days.' Any remaining Hindustanis would find